

Esoteric(ism) Western tradition of mystical, specialized knowledge held only by the privileged few and associated with the occult. Hermeticism, gnosticism, Rosicrucianism, and the Kabbalah are examples of esotericism.

Evil eye A curse believed to be cast by a malevolent gaze, usually fixed on a person when they are unaware.

Exorcism The process of forcing an evil spirit to leave a person or place by using prayers or magic.

Extispicy A type of divination carried out in ancient Mesopotamia and Greece by examining the entrails of a sheep.

Familiar A spirit, usually in the shape of a cat, bird, or other small domestic animal, that is the close companion of a witch and gives her magical powers.

Fetish An object that is worshipped in some societies because it is believed to have a spirit or special magical powers.

Folk healing The traditional art of medicine as practiced among (usually) rural communities, consisting typically of the use of herbal remedies, fruits, and vegetables thought to have healing power. Folk healers do not have professional qualifications like doctors or priests. *See also* Cunning folk.

Folk magic The magical practices of the common folk, rather than the ceremonial magic that was performed by the learned elite. Folk magic is generally practical and meant to address the common concerns of the community, such as healing the sick, bringing love or luck, driving away evil forces, finding lost items, bringing good harvests, granting fertility, and reading omens to tell the future.

Geomancy A method of divination that involves interpreting either markings on the ground or the patterns formed by tossed handfuls of soil, rocks, or sand.

Gnosticism A 2nd-century religious movement whose followers believed that knowledge and a pure life could set people

free from the material world, which had been created by an inferior god known as a demiurge.

Goetia A type of ceremonial magic that involves summoning demons.

Grimoire A term used from the 18th century onward to refer to a handbook of magic, often dating from the medieval period; also used by Wiccans to refer to the books used by individual practitioners to record their spells and rituals. *See also* Book of Shadows.

Hallucinogen A psychoactive agent that causes hallucinations and other major subjective changes in vision, thoughts, feelings, and consciousness.

Handfasting A rural folkloric and Neopagan custom, initially found in Western European countries, in which a couple hold a commitment ceremony.

Haruspicy In ancient Rome, interpreting omens by inspecting the entrails of animals, especially the livers of sheep and poultry. The religious official who carried out this role was called a haruspex.

Hepatomancy A type of ancient Greek divination that involved examining the livers of sacrificial animals.

Heresy Beliefs that contradict the doctrine of the Catholic Church.

Hermeticism Also called Hermetism, a religious, philosophical, and esoteric tradition based primarily on writings attributed to Hermes Trismegistus ("thrice-greatest Hermes").

Hoodoo Sympathetic and folk magic, originating partly in Central Africa and partly in the American Deep South, but now practiced particularly by African Americans in the southern US.

Horoscope A map of the heavens for a particular time and place indicating planetary positions and relationships, which is used to make predictions about personality, fate, events, natural phenomena, or the best times to do things.

Humors (four) Ancient Greek theory promoted by Hippocrates that became a mainstay of medical belief for two thousand years: the body was made up of four humors (components)—blood, phlegm, yellow bile, and black bile; diseases were caused by imbalances in the levels of the humors and could be cured by restoring their equilibrium.

Incantation (The performance of) words that are believed to have a magical effect when spoken or sung.

Initiate Someone who has been through a rite of passage (initiation) into a group or organization, such as a coven of witches or a Masonic lodge.

Kabbalah The ancient Jewish practice of mystical interpretation of the Tanakh (Hebrew Bible), first by word of mouth and then by secret codes. Some of its practices were taken up by Christian and Hermetic Kabbalah followers during the Renaissance.

Lecanomancy Looking for patterns in a dish of water, or observing the ripples created by a stone dropped into the water, to predict the future.

Macrocosm The whole of a large and complex structure, especially the world or the universe, in contrast to a small or representative part of it (the microcosm), such as humankind or an individual person.

Magick A spelling variant of magic, used by some practitioners, notably Aleister Crowley in the early 20th century, to differentiate their practices from conjuring.

Mandrake A Mediterranean plant of the nightshade family, with a forked, fleshy root that supposedly resembles the human form and which was formerly used in herbal medicine and magic; it was alleged to shriek when pulled from the ground.

Medium A person who claims to act as an intermediary between the living and the spirits of the dead.